
THE TRUE ORIGINAL SIN



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INTRODUCTION

The Fruit and the Body

There is a sentence, in the third chapter of Genesis, that readers almost always skim past too quickly, caught up in the theological drama of the broken prohibition, the serpent, the expulsion. It is a very short sentence, placed exactly at the point where the story changes register: the eyes of both were opened, and they realized they were naked. Just before, the previous chapter had closed with an equally brief and equally overlooked note: the man and the woman were naked, and felt no shame.

Naked and without shame, before. Eyes opened and ashamed of nakedness, after. Between these two verses lies the whole of original sin, the act Christian tradition would call the fall of man, the event that, according to centuries of theology, would generate the fallen condition of all humanity. And yet, if one looks closely at what exactly changes between the before and the after, what changes is not an abstract moral virtue. It is the perception of one's own body. It is nakedness, and the sexuality that nakedness implies.

This essay is born from a simple question that traditional theology tends to set aside quickly: why does the story of the first human transgression, the one that was supposed to found the very notion of sin, focus so insistently on the body, on nakedness, on shame, and not on some other, more abstract kind of guilt? Why, immediately after eating the fruit, do Adam and Eve feel no remorse for having

disobeyed, do not weep, do not beg forgiveness: they sew fig leaves and hide, like people who have discovered something about their own bodies they did not know before.

The traditional answer, the one that has run through two thousand years of Christian exegesis, says that shame over nakedness is only a symptom, the visible sign of a deeper rupture: the loss of the original harmony between man and God, between man and himself, between man and creation. Nakedness would not be the substance of the sin, but only its first perceptible consequence. It is a solid reading, supported by an immense theological tradition, and we will not dismiss it lightly.

But there is a second reading, older than commonly believed and more widespread than official theology is willing to admit, which takes those verses literally rather than as a symptom of something else. This reading holds that the forbidden fruit, the knowledge of good and evil, the discovered nakedness and the shame that follows, are not metaphors for a generic moral guilt, but the deliberately veiled account of the awakening of human sexuality. Not a sin against God committed through sex, but sexuality itself as what is acquired, or restored, at the moment of transgression.

This reading has a very long history and runs through traditions very different from one another, often in disagreement about almost everything else. We find it, in different forms, in ancient rabbinic thought, in the gnostic texts of the second century, in the theology of Augustine of Hippo, and finally, in more recent times, in the reconstructions of the ancient-astronaut tradition, which link it to a precise conflict between Mesopotamian divine entities over the reproductive capacity of the human species. These are readings born

in different eras, with different tools, and often hostile to one another. But they all share the same underlying intuition: that the true center of the story of Eden is not an abstract disobedience, but a much more concrete event, much more bodily, and much closer to what we are.

In this essay we will walk together through these readings, starting, as always, from the most solid ground, the philological and textual one, before venturing progressively into the most radical interpretations, always stating clearly where the established fact ends and the hypothesis begins. This is not a path that seeks to replace the traditional reading with a new orthodoxy. It is a path that seeks to give the text back its original strangeness, a strangeness that two thousand years of habit have smoothed over, and that, looked at closely, still has something precise to tell us.

It is worth clarifying, before we begin, why a subject that seems so intimate, the sexuality of two individuals who lived, according to the story, at the dawn of the world, deserves such an extensive inquiry. The reason is that the story of Eden is not only about Adam and Eve. It is the founding text through which entire civilizations, for millennia, have built their understanding of the relationship between body and guilt, between desire and dignity, between knowledge and the loss of innocence. Every reading this essay will examine, from the most cautious to the most radical, is not merely an attempt to decipher an ancient text: it is, at the same time, an attempt to understand why that particular page, among all the pages humanity could have chosen to tell its own origin, became so enduring, so capable of generating ever-new interpretations, so stubbornly centered on the moment a body, for the first time, saw itself.

Because if the fruit of Eden was not simply about obedience, a question remains that

neither of the two great traditions, the theological and the alternative, can afford to avoid: what really opened, that day, in the eyes of the first man and the first woman?

CHAPTER 1

The Tree and the Prohibition

To understand the scope of what happens in the third chapter of Genesis, one must first carefully reconstruct the scene that precedes it, because it is a scene built with a symmetry rarely noticed, and one that is itself part of the message.

In the second chapter of Genesis, God places man in the garden of Eden and entrusts him with a task, to cultivate and keep it, together with a single prohibition: of every tree of the garden he may freely eat, but of the tree of the knowledge of good and evil he shall not eat, for in the day he eats of it he shall surely die. It is an isolated, dry prohibition, unaccompanied by any explanation of why that particular tree is forbidden, or of what exactly it means to know good and evil. The text simply states the rule and its penalty.

Immediately afterward, the story introduces the creation of the woman, drawn from the man's rib, and closes the chapter with a verse that at first glance looks like a simple note of family history, but which is in fact a crucial hinge of the entire narrative: therefore a man shall leave his father and his mother and cleave to his wife, and they shall become one flesh. It is the first explicit reference, in the whole Bible, to the physical union between a man and a woman, and it is placed, not by chance, in the very last verse of the chapter preceding the account of the transgression. The text thus closes the second chapter with the image of two beings who are one flesh, adding, in the last line: they were both naked, the man and his wife, and felt no

shame.

This is not a neutral description. It is the establishment of a state, a state the next chapter will destroy. Nakedness without shame is not a decorative detail of the Edenic setting: it is the condition that will be explicitly reversed two verses after the beginning of chapter three, when the eyes of the two will open and shame will replace innocence. The text, in other words, is deliberately constructing a before and an after, and the criterion distinguishing the two states is not the theoretical knowledge of good and evil in the abstract, but the relationship between the two human beings and their own bodies.

The prohibition itself deserves attention. The tree is called the tree of the knowledge of good and evil, an expression exegetes have interpreted in different ways over the centuries. Some read it as a merism, a Hebrew rhetorical figure that uses two opposite extremes to indicate a totality, the way saying from the small to the great means everything, regardless of size. In this reading, to know good and evil would mean acquiring total, all-encompassing knowledge, an attribute that in Hebrew tradition properly belongs only to God. Other interpreters have instead proposed a more specific reading, tied to the use the expression good and evil has elsewhere in the Hebrew Bible in contexts concerning adult moral and practical judgment, the maturity needed to govern, to distinguish what is beneficial from what is harmful.

Neither of these two readings, in itself, necessarily implies a reference to sexuality. But it is significant that the text, right after introducing this tree with such a broad and ambiguous name, chooses to show us its effects not through a sudden capacity for abstract ethical judgment, not through a new moral competence demonstrated in action, but

through a single, specific perceptual change: the discovery of one's own nakedness. If the text had wanted to show the acquisition of general ethical knowledge, it could have done so with a scene of moral choice, a dilemma, a decision. It chooses instead to show us this through the body.

There is then a second tree in the garden, mentioned alongside the first from the very beginning of the story: the tree of life, likewise placed at the center of the garden. No explicit prohibition weighs on this second tree at first; the prohibition arrives only after the transgression, when God, fearing that man might also reach out his hand toward that tree and live forever, decides to expel him from the garden. But it is on the first tree, that of knowledge, that we focus our attention in this essay, because it is there that the most specific and most overlooked anomaly of the entire Edenic narrative lies hidden.

There is a strand of academic scholarship, developed in particular by the biblical scholar Gordon Wenham and taken up by numerous later scholars, that reads the entire garden of Eden not simply as an idyllic natural setting, but as a sanctuary, a place that shares a surprising number of architectural and symbolic features with the tabernacle and the Jerusalem temple described in later books of the Hebrew Bible. God walking in the garden, man placed there to cultivate and keep it, verbs that elsewhere in the Bible specifically describe priestly service in the temple, the eastern entrance guarded by cherubim, decorative elements that would later recur, embroidered on the veils of the sanctuary, in the Mosaic tabernacle: all these details, according to this reading, indicate that Eden should be understood as the cosmic prototype of every future Israelite place of worship, a space in which man lives in the direct presence of God like a priest in his sanctuary.

This reading, fully academic and independent of any hypothesis about sexuality, adds a further layer of meaning to the expulsion: driving Adam and Eve out of the garden would amount, in this light, to an expulsion from the priesthood itself, a loss of direct access to the sacred not unlike the one that, centuries later, would separate the common people from the Holy of Holies kept behind the temple veil.

The prohibition, finally, is accompanied by a precise threat: in the day you eat of it, you shall surely die. But when the transgression occurs, in the following chapter, Adam does not die that day. He will go on to live, according to the genealogy in the fifth chapter of Genesis, another nine hundred and thirty years. This discrepancy between the threat and its non-immediate fulfillment has generated, over the centuries, a vast body of exegetical literature, proposing different readings: death as a process that begins that day even though it is completed much later, spiritual death distinct from physical death, the threat as a warning not necessarily meant literally. We will keep this anomaly in mind, because it will prove useful later, when we address the most radical hypothesis of this essay.

For now, what matters is the structure the text carefully builds: two beings naked and without shame, a forbidden tree whose name alludes to total knowledge or to moral maturity, a threat of death that is not immediately fulfilled, and a second tree, that of life, which will become relevant only later. It is a structure that, read carefully, prepares exactly the ground for the linguistic anomaly we will address in the next chapter: the very verb the Bible will use, a few lines further on, to describe what happens between Adam and Eve after the expulsion from the garden.

CHAPTER 2

To Know, in the Biblical Sense

There is a linguistic detail in the Hebrew Bible that every reader of the original text knows but that is almost always lost in translation, and it is the philological hinge around which this entire essay turns. The Hebrew verb *yada*, which we generally translate as to know, does not indicate only an intellectual operation, the acquisition of information or a skill. In the Hebrew Bible, the very same verb is used, with complete naturalness and without needing any explanation for the ancient reader, to indicate the sexual act.

The most direct example is found in the chapter immediately following the expulsion from Eden. The fourth chapter of Genesis opens with these words: and the man knew Eve his wife, and she conceived and bore Cain. The verb is the same, *yada*, identical to the one used for the tree of the knowledge of good and evil. This is not an isolated case: the same usage appears later in Genesis itself, when it says that Cain knew his wife, and she conceived, and it recurs in numerous other books of the Hebrew Bible whenever the text needs to allude to a sexual relationship without describing it explicitly. It is a documented linguistic usage, recognized by every grammar and every lexicon of biblical Hebrew, and requires no forced interpretation: to know, in certain contexts, means to have sexual relations.

This philological fact, in itself neutral and undeniable, takes on particular weight when applied to the name of the forbidden tree. The

tree of the knowledge of good and evil is, literally, the tree of yada tov vara. And the first explicit, immediate, non-symbolic effect of eating its fruit is that the eyes of both were opened, and they knew that they were naked. The text here uses not the verb yada but another verb, one of visual perception, and yet the whole scene is built around the opening of the eyes onto a specifically bodily fact, mutual nakedness, in a lexical context in which the term knowledge, a few lines earlier, had been chosen to name the tree, and a few lines later will be used to explicitly name the sexual act between the same two protagonists.

It is important to be precise about what this fact does and does not prove. It does not automatically and definitively prove that the tree of knowledge symbolically represents sexuality. The majority of academic commentators, including rigorous philologists such as Robert Alter, whose translation and commentary on the first books of the Bible remain a fundamental reference, argue that the expression knowledge of good and evil should be read in the broader sense of moral maturity and general discernment, not as a specific and narrow reference to the sexual sphere alone. This reading has good arguments in its favor: the expression good and evil, elsewhere in the Bible, covers a range of meanings well beyond sexuality, including the capacity to govern, to administer justice, to distinguish the useful from the harmful in general.

But a fact remains that this broader reading cannot erase: whatever the full meaning of the expression knowledge of good and evil, the text chooses to show us its acquisition, in practice, through a single concrete scene, and it is a scene concerning the perception of nakedness. If the author had wanted to illustrate general moral

knowledge, he could have chosen countless other scenes, an ethical dilemma, a choice between good and evil in action. He chooses instead to show us two people who suddenly realize they are naked, feel ashamed, and cover themselves. The knowledge acquired, whatever its theoretical scope, manifests narratively in only one way, and it is a way that concerns the body and its mutual exposure.

The examples do not stop at the fourth chapter of Genesis. In the book of Numbers, when Moses orders that only the women who have not known a man by lying with him be spared, the text again uses *yada* to specify, with no possible ambiguity, the absence of sexual relations. In the book of Judges, the same expression recurs to describe the women of Jabesh-gilead who had not known a man. In the first book of Samuel, when it is told that Elkanah knew Hannah his wife, the verb again introduces, without mediation, a marital relationship followed by conception. This usage, then, is not an isolated exception tied only to the fourth chapter of Genesis, but a stable and recurring linguistic usage throughout the whole corpus of the Hebrew Bible, so widespread that lexicons and grammars of biblical Hebrew record it as one of the regular meanings of the verb, alongside the purely intellectual one.

It is worth pausing here to clear up a widespread popular misconception concerning the very nature of the forbidden fruit. For centuries the Western collective imagination has associated original sin with an apple, an association so deeply rooted that it seems almost part of the biblical text itself. In reality, the Hebrew text of Genesis does not specify at all what kind of fruit grew on the tree of knowledge: it simply speaks of fruit, *peri*, with no further botanical detail. The association with the apple arises much later, probably

from a pun in the Latin translation of the Bible, Jerome's Vulgate, in which the word *malum* means both apple and evil, an assonance too elegant for later popular imagination, especially in medieval and Renaissance art and literature, not to seize upon permanently. This detail, however marginal to the central theme of this essay, shows how much the cultural reception of a text can add layers of meaning entirely absent from the original, and it is a useful reminder of the need to always return to the Hebrew text when discussing its original meaning, rather than relying on the images later tradition has settled into place.

There is a second linguistic detail that reinforces this picture, and it is less well known to the general public. The Hebrew term *arum*, used to describe the serpent as the most cunning or crafty of all the beasts of the field in the first verse of chapter three, is nearly identical, in its consonantal root, to the term *arom*, used just one verse earlier, at the end of chapter two, to describe the naked condition of Adam and Eve. The Hebrew text deliberately plays on this sound resemblance: the couple were *arummim*, naked, and the serpent was *arum*, crafty. It is a wordplay ancient rabbinic commentators already noted, and some have read it as a further sign of the close link, intended by the text itself, between the theme of nakedness and the character who triggers the transgression.

These philological elements taken together, the verb *yada* linking the name of the tree to the sexual act performed a few lines later, the wordplay between nakedness and cunning, the narrative choice to represent acquired knowledge solely through the discovery of nakedness, do not conclusively prove that original sin is, strictly speaking, a veiled account of sexual awakening. But they do prove,

and this in a documented way verifiable by anyone who knows biblical Hebrew, that the text itself chose a language that makes that reading anything but arbitrary. We are not projecting onto the text a meaning foreign to it. We are observing that the text itself, in its most basic vocabulary, constantly holds in tension the two meanings of knowledge, the intellectual and the sexual, never fully resolving them into one or the other.

This ambiguity is not a weakness of the story. It is, in all likelihood, part of its intended structure. A text that wanted to exclude every sexual reference could have chosen a different verb to name the tree, or avoided reusing the same verb, *yada*, so close in the narrative, to describe the union between Adam and Eve immediately after the expulsion. The fact that it did so, in a text elsewhere extremely attentive to lexical choice, as the whole tradition of scholarship on the composition of Genesis demonstrates, is a fact that deserves to be taken seriously, not filed away as a coincidence without weight.

With this philological foundation in place, we can now return to the central scene of the story, that of the opening of the eyes and the discovery of nakedness, and observe it with the closer attention it deserves.

CHAPTER 3

Naked and Unashamed

Every well-built story has a hinge, a precise point at which everything changes. In the story of Eden that hinge is remarkably brief, just two verses, and yet it carries the entire narrative and theological weight of the whole episode. It is worth reading them side by side, exactly as the text arranges them.

The last verse of chapter two reads: they were both naked, the man and his wife, and felt no shame. The seventh verse of chapter three, immediately after the scene in which both eat the fruit, reads: then the eyes of both were opened, and they knew that they were naked; and they sewed fig leaves together and made themselves loincloths. Between these two verses, separated only by the dialogue with the serpent and the act of eating the fruit, the entire event later tradition would call original sin takes place.

What is striking, reading these two verses in sequence and without the filter of two thousand years of later theological elaboration, is how little the text dwells on any other consequence of the transgression before arriving at nakedness. There is, at this point in the story, no mention of an inwardly perceived change in the relationship between man and God, no description of a tormented conscience, no verbalized remorse. There is only, immediately, the physical perception of mutual nakedness, followed by the practical gesture of covering themselves with fig leaves. The text then continues, right afterward, with God walking in the garden in the cool of the day and

calling to Adam, who answers that he hid himself because he was afraid, being naked. Once again it is nakedness, and no other guilt, that is the explicit focus of Adam's attention and, implicitly, of the question God asks him immediately afterward: who told you that you were naked? Have you eaten from the tree I commanded you not to eat from?

This question of God's deserves a pause. Who told you that you were naked is a logically curious question, because Adam's physical nakedness had, obviously, always been visible, ever since his creation. What changed is not the nakedness itself, which was a constant fact, but the awareness of it, the capacity to perceive it as such, as something requiring concealment. The text draws a precise distinction between an unchanged physical fact, the naked body, and a new perceptual state, the awareness of that nakedness and the discomfort that follows. This is exactly the structure of an awakening, not of an objective physical change: something that was not seen before is now seen, and what changes is the observer, not the observed.

The punishment that follows further reinforces this bodily picture. To the woman God says: I will greatly multiply your pain and your childbearing; in pain you shall bring forth children, and your desire shall be for your husband, and he shall rule over you. Every single element of this sentence concerns the sexual and reproductive sphere: the pain of childbirth, pregnancy, desire for the husband, the power dynamic between the sexes. Not a single word, in this specific verdict addressed to the woman, concerns anything other than sexuality and procreation. For the man, by contrast, the punishment concerns the labor of the ground, the toil of securing food, a different sphere but

equally concrete and bodily, nothing abstract or purely spiritual.

This association between nakedness and vulnerability is not an isolated invention of the Edenic narrative, but a motif that recurs elsewhere in the Hebrew Bible with a consistent meaning. The prophet Isaiah, for three years, walks barefoot and naked through the streets as a prophetic sign against Egypt and Cush, a gesture the text explicitly presents as a symbol of humiliation and coming captivity, not as a neutral condition. The book of Ezekiel, in chapter sixteen, describes Jerusalem as an abandoned newborn, naked and covered in blood, and then as a bride whom God clothes in precious garments, only to strip her naked again as punishment for her unfaithfulness, an oscillation between nakedness and clothing that structures the entire parable as a sign of social standing, of dignity granted or revoked. In none of these passages is nakedness presented as a neutral or merely physical state: it is always, systematically, a sign of loss, of vulnerability, of a degraded condition relative to a previous clothed dignity. Read in light of these parallels internal to the Bible itself, the passage from unashamed nakedness in Eden to ashamed nakedness after the transgression fits into a symbolic code consistent with the rest of the Hebrew Scriptures, a code in which the uncovered body is never simply an anatomical fact, but always an indicator of condition, of status, of relationship with others and with the sacred.

The very expression used to describe this awakening deserves further philological attention. The eyes of both were opened is not an isolated expression in the biblical vocabulary: the same formula, the opening of the eyes as a sign of a sudden capacity to perceive something previously invisible, recurs in at least two other significant episodes of the Hebrew Bible. When the angel of the Lord opposes Balaam's

path, it is only after God opens his eyes that the foreign prophet finally manages to see the angel's drawn sword, invisible until that moment despite being right there in front of him the whole time. And when the servant of the prophet Elisha, terrified by the enemy army surrounding the city, is reassured by the prophet, it is again the opening of the eyes, performed directly by God at Elisha's request, that reveals to him the chariots of fire and horses of fire filling the mountain, presences that were real but ordinarily imperceptible to the naked eye. In both these episodes, as in Eden, the opening of the eyes does not describe new information learned intellectually, but a change in the subject's very perceptual capacity, allowing him to see what had, until that moment, simply been closed off from his sight. Applied to the scene in Eden, this same formula suggests that Adam and Eve's nakedness was not a newly created fact, as we have already observed, but a fact already present and real that the two simply were not, until that moment, biologically or perceptually able to register as such.

One last linguistic piece, added to those already gathered in the previous chapter, concerns another Hebrew term for nakedness, distinct from *arom* but equally relevant: *ervah*. This term, which likewise denotes nakedness or the intimate part of the body, is the technical word the book of Leviticus systematically uses in its list of forbidden sexual unions, where the expression to uncover someone's nakedness, *gillah ervah*, is the standard idiom by which biblical law designates the forbidden sexual act between blood relatives or in-laws. The fact that biblical Hebrew has a specific technical vocabulary in which the concept of uncovered nakedness literally coincides with the sexual act itself, not as an occasional poetic

metaphor but as current legal terminology in the law codes, shows how deeply, in the ancient Hebrew linguistic mindset, the semantic field of nakedness was structurally and permanently intertwined with that of sexuality, well beyond the single episode of Eden. Reading the scene of the discovery of nakedness in Genesis three in light of this later legal vocabulary is not an anachronism: it is recognizing that the very language in which the story is written did not offer its first readers the possibility of neatly separating, as our modern sensibility does, the physical fact of nakedness from the sexual meaning it carried.

If we line up these elements, the discovery of nakedness, God's question about the source of that awareness, the punishment of the woman centered entirely on pregnancy and marital desire, the picture that emerges is that of a text which, repeatedly and at every point immediately following the transgression, keeps insisting on the bodily and sexual dimension of the episode, never deviating toward other domains. This is not the only possible reading, and we will repeat this until the end of this essay: the theology of guilt as a general rupture in the relationship with God remains legitimate and supported by an immense tradition. But anyone reading these verses without immediately overlaying that tradition would find it hard not to notice how insistently the text chooses to speak of bodies, of nakedness, of childbirth and desire, rather than of abstract rebellion or spiritual pride, themes that later theology would nonetheless place at the center of the interpretation of original sin.

There is, finally, one last element of this scene worth observing closely, and it is the very gesture of covering. Adam and Eve do not hide in some generic way, do not cover their faces, do not simply take

refuge in the shade of the trees to avoid God's gaze in a general sense. They sew fig leaves specifically to make themselves loincloths, a garment that covers, specifically and deliberately, the genital area. It is a practical, almost technical detail, one the text includes with no narrative necessity if the true subject were purely spiritual guilt. If the author had wanted to tell of a generic shame at having disobeyed God, there would have been no reason to specify which part of the body the two characters felt the need to cover. The fact that the text does specify it, and chooses precisely that part of the body, is a further piece that adds itself, with no need for interpretive strain, to the picture this essay is building.

There remains, at this point, one last structural anomaly to examine, perhaps the most surprising of all because it is rarely brought into focus: what does not happen in the garden of Eden before the expulsion. That is the subject of the next chapter.

CHAPTER 4

The First Child

There is a structural fact in the story of Genesis that, once noticed, becomes impossible not to see, and that the traditional reading, focused on the drama of disobedience, nonetheless systematically leaves in the background: no child is born in the garden of Eden. Adam and Eve live in the garden, according to the story, for an unspecified but presumably not brief time, and yet the text mentions no pregnancy, no birth, no child conceived before the expulsion. The first explicitly narrated sexual act, the one introduced by the verb *yada* we examined in the second chapter of this essay, and the first birth that follows from it, that of Cain, both occur only after the expulsion from the garden, at the opening of the fourth chapter of Genesis.

This is a textual fact, not an inference. The text never says that Adam and Eve had children while in Eden. It says, at the end of chapter two, that the two were one flesh and lived naked without shame. It says, in chapter four, right after the expulsion narrated in chapter three, that the man knew his wife and she conceived. The narrative sequence, taken as it stands, places the beginning of human procreation not in the garden, in a state of innocence, but outside it, after the transgression, as its direct consequence or at least as an event immediately following it.

This observation opens a question traditional commentators have addressed in different ways over the centuries. If Adam and Eve were

already joined as one flesh before the expulsion, according to the expression used at the end of chapter two, why do they not have children until they are outside the garden? A common answer, held by various Jewish and Christian commentators throughout the history of exegesis, is that the time spent in Eden was in fact very short, perhaps a single day according to some rabbinic traditions, too short for a pregnancy to be completed before the expulsion. It is a plausible solution from a narrative and chronological standpoint, and requires no extraordinary hypothesis.

But there is an alternative reading, developed especially in certain more speculative strands of rabbinic exegesis and later taken up by subsequent traditions, according to which the absence of procreation in Eden would not be a simple matter of insufficient time, but the sign of an original condition in which the reproductive capacity itself was not yet active, or had not yet been granted. In this reading, the union as one flesh mentioned at the end of chapter two would describe a bond, a communion, perhaps even a form of intimacy, but not necessarily a sexual act in the full, fertile sense the text will explicitly describe, with the verb *yada*, only after the expulsion. The awakening of procreative sexuality, in this view, does not precede the transgression: it follows it, or coincides with it.

There is a further philological detail that reinforces the structural link between the two sentences pronounced on Eve and on Adam, one biblical Hebrew scholars have long noted. The word translated as pain or suffering in the woman's condemnation, *itzavon*, shares the same consonantal root as the word used a few verses later to describe the man's toil in working the ground, also *itzavon*. The Hebrew text, in other words, deliberately chooses the same term to describe the

woman's reproductive suffering and the man's laboring suffering, building a lexical parallelism no translation can fully render. The two sentences, that of childbirth and that of the toil of the fields, are not only thematically parallel, both concerning the survival of the species, one through reproduction and the other through sustenance, but are bound together by the very same word the text chooses to name them. This further reinforces the impression that the third chapter of Genesis builds its two main sentences around a single, coherent logic: the post-Edenic condition of humanity, for both man and woman, is defined entirely through the labor of the body, reproductive for the one, agricultural for the other, and in no case through categories foreign to the physical and material sphere of survival.

There is a further chronological detail, internal to the text itself, that reinforces the picture just outlined. When the fifth chapter of Genesis resumes Adam's formal genealogy, it specifies that Adam fathered a son in his own image, Seth, at the age of a hundred and thirty. But Seth is not Adam's first son: he is preceded by Cain and Abel, born, according to the narrative sequence of chapter four, before that date. The text, however, never gives Adam's age at Cain's birth, the only birth for which this data point is missing in the otherwise scrupulously accounted genealogy of chapter five. This is an absence that could be explained in many ways, as a simple omission due to the merging of different sources in the final redaction of the text, a hypothesis supported by modern historical criticism of the composition of the Pentateuch. But it is nonetheless significant that the only birth lacking a precise chronological placement in the entire genealogical framework of Genesis is precisely the first one, the one the text places immediately after the expulsion from Eden, as though

the exact, administrative chronology governing the rest of the list did not yet fully apply to this first, immediate passage from the Edenic condition to the historical one.

There exists, alongside this discussion, a further post-biblical Jewish tradition worth at least a mention, though it belongs to a distinct and later legendary strand than the text of Genesis: the figure of Lilith. A medieval text known as the Alphabet of Ben Sira, of uncertain origin but gathering older oral traditions, tells that God created a first woman, Lilith, from the same earth from which Adam was drawn, even before Eve. According to this legend, Lilith refused to submit to Adam, particularly in the sexual act, claiming equal dignity derived from their identical origin, and eventually left Eden by pronouncing the secret name of God, becoming, in later Jewish folklore, a nocturnal demonic figure. This tradition, external to the canonical text and of much later formation, nonetheless testifies to how long, within Jewish culture, the question of the sexual and reproductive relations of the first human couple continued to generate supplementary narratives, almost filling a silence the text of Genesis leaves open from the very beginning.

This second reading finds indirect but significant support in the very structure of the punishment inflicted on the woman, which we already examined in the previous chapter: I will greatly multiply your pain and your childbearing. The verb to multiply presupposes that something already exists, but here it is applied to pregnancies that, as we have seen, the text has not yet narrated before this point. If we read the divine sentence as an announcement addressed to a capacity about to be activated, rather than as a simple intensification of an already-experienced process, the whole passage acquires a coherence

the more superficial reading misses: the woman is not punished by having something she already did made more painful, she is informed of the consequences of a capacity that, from that moment, becomes part of her condition.

This reading, it must be said with the usual methodological honesty of this essay, is not the majority view among contemporary exegetes, who tend to prefer more cautious explanations tied to the brevity of the Edenic sojourn or to the literary, non-chronicle-like nature of the narrative. But neither is it an invention without roots in the history of interpretation: traces of this idea, that of a procreative sexuality activated or transformed precisely at the moment of the expulsion, appear in various ancient midrashic sources, some of which go so far as to imagine that Adam and Eve, in the garden, possessed a nature partly different from the one they would take on outside it, a nature some texts describe, as we will see in a later chapter, in terms of a body clothed in light rather than the mortal skin they would wear after the expulsion.

If we accept, even merely as an interpretive key to keep open, that human procreative sexuality is narratively placed by the text not before but after, or at the very moment of, the transgression, then the whole episode of Eden takes on a shape different from that of simple moral disobedience. It becomes the story of a threshold crossed, the moment humanity, to use the very words God pronounces immediately after the transgression, addressing a group of heavenly listeners in the first-person plural, man has become like one of us, acquires something it did not possess before, something that for the first time inducts it into the cycle of life and death through procreation, sharply distinguishing it from its previous condition.

To explore this possibility further we must now widen our view beyond the biblical text, and observe how a structurally identical theme, a being who loses an original state of innocence precisely through a sexual initiation, appears in a Mesopotamian text far older than the final redaction of Genesis, a text few readers of the Bible know but that Assyriologists have long considered one of the closest parallels to the story of Eden.

CHAPTER 5

Enkidu and the Sacred Prostitute

In the Epic of Gilgamesh, the great Mesopotamian epic poem for which Andrew George's critical translation remains today the most authoritative reference in English, there appears a character Assyriologists have connected to Adam ever since the earliest decades after the poem was deciphered and made known in the West: Enkidu, the wild man created by the gods to counter the arrogance of King Gilgamesh.

Enkidu, when he first appears in the poem, is not at all a civilized being. He lives on the steppe among the wild animals, feeds on grass like them, drinks at the same watering holes, and protects them from hunters' traps. He is strong, hairy, devoid of any human institution, but also innocent in a sense very close to how Genesis describes Adam before the transgression: he lives in total harmony with wild nature, without shame, without culture, without any awareness of himself as a being distinct from the animals around him.

Gilgamesh, alarmed by the strength of this wild being disturbing the region's hunters, decides to civilize him, and the method he chooses is specific and left to no ambiguity: he sends into the steppe a woman, a temple priestess of the goddess Ishtar named Shamhat, with instructions to offer herself to Enkidu and initiate him into the pleasures of the human body. The text describes the scene with a detail striking for a poem of this age: Shamhat bares herself before Enkidu, and he unites with her for six days and seven nights straight.

It is what happens immediately afterward that makes this episode one of the most discussed parallels with the story of Eden. The text explicitly says that, after uniting with Shamhat, Enkidu tries to return to the wild animals he had lived among until then, but the gazelles and the other beasts of the steppe flee from him in fear. His body, the poem says, no longer has the same strength in running as before, but in exchange, the text adds, Enkidu now has understanding, has acquired wisdom. He is no longer one of the animals. He has become, literally, human, and he has become so through a single specific event: sexual union with Shamhat, which opened in him an understanding he did not possess before and which, at the same time, irreparably separated him from the natural world in which he had lived before in perfect harmony.

It is worth noting, in this regard, a detail that interestingly reverses the parallel between the two stories. Before the creation of Eve, the text of Genesis shows Adam naming all the animals of the field and all the birds of the sky, exercising over them a form of authority and taxonomic distance: man observes, classifies, dominates, but does not live among the animals as one of them. Enkidu, by contrast, before meeting Shamhat, does not dominate the animals of the steppe: he lives among them, feeds as they do, protects them, is one of them in every respect. The two stories thus move from opposite starting points, an Adam already distinct from the animals in position and authority from the start, an Enkidu still undistinguished from them, but they converge on the same outcome after the sexual event that marks them both: a further and definitive separation from the animal world, accompanied by a new, uncomfortable self-awareness, and by a relationship with nakedness and one's own body that was not even

conceivable as a problem before.

The parallel with Adam and Eve has been noted and discussed by leading academic scholars, including Jeffrey Tigay, whose study of the textual evolution of the Epic of Gilgamesh remains a fundamental reference in the field. The structure is strikingly overlapping: a being living in original harmony with nature and with animals, devoid of shame or self-awareness; a specifically sexual initiation introducing an irreversible change; the acquisition, as a direct consequence of that union, of a form of knowledge or wisdom that did not exist before; and finally the expulsion, not from a physically bounded place like the garden of Eden, but from the very condition of belonging to the animal world, replaced by a new, more fragile and more conscious, belonging to the human world.

It must be said, with the methodological honesty guiding this essay, that these are two independent texts, produced in different cultures, with different narrative purposes: the Epic of Gilgamesh has no theological intention of explaining the origin of sin or of humanity's mortal condition in the way Genesis does, and Enkidu is not a progenitor of humanity but a single secondary hero in the story of another man, Gilgamesh.

The figure of Shamhat herself deserves historical elaboration, because she is not an isolated narrative invention but reflects a real and widely documented religious institution in ancient Mesopotamia: that of temple priestesses dedicated to the cult of the goddess Ishtar, known in Akkadian sources by terms such as *qadishtu*, the consecrated one. The Greek historian Herodotus, in the fifth century BCE, describes in detail, in the first book of his *Histories*, the Babylonian custom whereby every woman had, at least once in her life, to go to the

goddess's temple and unite with a stranger in her honor before returning to her ordinary life. Although modern Assyriologists debate how faithfully Herodotus's account reflects the real practice or offers a version distorted by a foreign observer's gaze, the very fact that such a religious institution, explicitly linking sexuality and the sacred, was a recognizable feature of Mesopotamian religiosity gives Shamhat a precise historical, not merely literary, placement: the poem assigns the task of civilizing Enkidu not to a generic figure, but to a representative of a real religious institution, the same one that, in the culture of those who wrote the poem, linked sexuality to a sacred and transformative dimension. We cannot say with certainty that the authors of Genesis knew this specific episode directly, though it is well documented that Mesopotamian literary traditions and those that flowed into the Hebrew Bible shared a broad common narrative heritage, widespread throughout the ancient Near East.

But regardless of the question of any direct dependence, the value of this parallel for our essay lies in confirming that the idea of sexual initiation as a threshold between an animal state, innocent and devoid of self-awareness, and a human state, conscious and permanently altered, is not a modern invention retroactively projected onto the biblical text. It is a narrative motif attested, independently, in at least two traditions of the ancient Near East, both interested in telling the origin of the human condition through very similar categories: prior animal innocence, the specific sexual event that interrupts it, the knowledge acquired as a direct consequence of that event, and the irreversible separation from a simpler and more harmonious previous state.

If the Enkidu episode shows us that this narrative pattern circulated in

the ancient world independently of the story of Genesis, it remains to ask what happened, according to later Hebrew tradition, to the very body of Adam and Eve at the moment of passage from one state to the other. Because there exists, right after the scene of shame and fig leaves, a detail the biblical text mentions almost in passing, but which part of the later interpretive tradition would develop in a surprising direction: a change not only perceptual, but physical, in the very nature of the human body.

CHAPTER 6

The Garments of Skin and the Changed Body

Toward the end of the third chapter of Genesis, right before the final expulsion from the garden, the text includes a short and seemingly marginal verse that an important part of Jewish and Christian interpretive tradition has nonetheless considered laden with meaning: the Lord God made for Adam and his wife garments of skin, and clothed them.

At first glance this verse seems a simple act of practical care: God, before expelling the two into a harsher world, provides them a garment more durable than the fig leaves they had sewn themselves. But ancient commentators have long dwelt on a specific detail: the Hebrew text here uses the word *or*, skin, spelled with the letter *ayin*, while other passages of rabbinic tradition discuss a wordplay, transmitted in certain midrashic sources, between this word and a nearly homophonous term spelled with a different consonant, *aleph* instead of *ayin*, meaning instead light. Some ancient rabbinic masters, according to this tradition, held that the original Torah given to Moses actually read garments of light, not garments of skin, and that Adam and Eve, before the transgression, were clothed in a luminous substance that, after the fall, condensed into the material, mortal skin we know today.

This tradition, which the reader will find developed in various sources of later Jewish mysticism, must be treated with the caution it deserves: it is not the dominant interpretation in classical rabbinic

reading of the verse, and not all scholars accept the authenticity or antiquity of the wordplay between light and skin. But its persistence over the centuries, flowing eventually into the kabbalistic literature of the Zohar, testifies to how deeply part of Jewish tradition felt that the passage narrated at this point in Genesis was not merely a change in moral status, but a change in the very substance of the human body: from an original body, subtle or luminous, to a dense, opaque, sexed, and mortal one.

Even before Augustine, another leading figure of Hellenistic Jewish tradition had already proposed a reading of the Edenic story strongly centered on the dimension of the senses and desire: the philosopher Philo of Alexandria, who lived in the first century, a contemporary of Jesus and of Paul of Tarsus. In his work known as the *Allegorical Interpretation of the Law*, Philo interprets the entire episode of Eden as a symbolic representation of the inner faculties of the human being: Adam would represent the intellect, Eve sense-perception, and the serpent pleasure, *hedone* in Greek, the force that first seduces the senses and then, through them, corrupts the intellect itself. In this reading too, more philosophical and less explicitly sexual than Augustine's later one, the center of the story remains the relationship between the body, its senses, the pleasure derived from them, and the reason that should govern them but is instead overwhelmed in the story. Philo writes almost four centuries before Augustine, and his work, though marginal to the rabbinic Judaism that would develop after the destruction of the Second Temple, shows that reading original sin as an episode intimately tied to the body, the senses, and pleasure has roots reaching back to the first century, long before Christianity developed its own specific doctrine of concupiscence.

A structurally similar echo, though developed with entirely different conceptual tools, is found in the Western Christian tradition, tied to the name of one of its most influential thinkers: Augustine of Hippo. In his works, particularly *The City of God* and the *Confessions*, Augustine develops an extensive reflection on the link between original sin and what he calls concupiscence, a technical term that in his theology specifically denotes disordered sexual desire, experienced as a force escaping the rational control of the will. For Augustine, the clearest sign of the fall is not an abstract corruption of the soul, but a concrete fact observable in every human being: sexual arousal, unlike almost every other bodily function, does not fully answer to the command of the will, and this insubordination of the body is, according to Augustine, precisely the physical legacy Adam's sin left to all his descendants.

Even later rabbinic tradition, without ever developing a doctrine identical to Augustinian concupiscence, elaborated a concept complementary to it in certain respects: that of the *yetzer hara*, the inclination to evil, a force present in every human being from birth and frequently associated, in Talmudic and later midrashic texts, precisely with sexual desire. Some passages of the Babylonian Talmud go so far as to say that if the *yetzer hara* were entirely removed from the world, no one would build a house, take a wife, or have children, openly acknowledging the very close link, in rabbinic thought, between the drive held responsible for sin and the same energy sustaining the continuity of the species through procreation. Unlike the Augustinian reading, rabbinic tradition does not regard the *yetzer hara* as a direct and specific consequence of Adam's sin, but as a structural component of human nature since creation, one that can

be channeled toward good through marriage and observance of the law, or left unchecked until it produces evil. It remains significant, nonetheless, that two sister religious traditions, the rabbinic and the early Christian, independently developed theological concepts placing sexual desire in so central and so ambivalent a position in their reflection on human nature and its fall.

The historian Peter Brown, in his now-classic study of the body and sexuality in early Christianity, has reconstructed with great precision how this Augustinian reflection, far from being a marginal speculation, became one of the pillars of Western theology of original sin for over a millennium, conveying the idea that sexuality itself, not merely its abuse, bore the imprinted scar of the Edenic transgression. This is a historically relevant fact for our essay, because it shows that reading original sin as an event intimately tied to sexuality is by no means a modern invention or a marginal deviation from orthodoxy: it was, for much of the history of Western Christianity, the dominant reading, upheld by one of its most authoritative theologians, not an alternative or heterodox interpretation.

It is important, at this point, to distinguish precisely between the different levels of this tradition. That Augustine linked original sin to sexual concupiscence is a documented historical fact, not a hypothesis. That the garments of skin represent, in ancient Jewish tradition, a real physical transformation of the human body from a luminous substance to a material one is an idea attested in later mystical sources, but not universally shared even within Jewish tradition itself, and should therefore be presented as a specific interpretive current, not as the consensus of the tradition as a whole. What both traditions share, though starting from different and non-

communicating premises, is the conviction that something more than mere moral conscience changed at that moment: that the human body itself, in its sexed and mortal nature, is in some way the direct consequence, and not merely the symbolic seat, of the event narrated in the garden.

This brings us to an interpretive fork in the road the rest of this essay must confront. If the change narrated in Eden concerns, as these traditions suggest, the very nature of the body and its reproductive function, then two completely different paths remain open for explaining its ultimate meaning. The first, developed by the gnostic tradition of the early Christian centuries, overturns the moral judgment on the entire event, reading the acquisition of bodily awareness not as a fall but as a liberation. The second, developed by the modern ancient-astronaut tradition, proposes that the physical change narrated in Eden is not symbolic at all, but the distorted memory of a real biological intervention, carried out by entities with the technical capacity to alter the reproductive physiology of the human species. We will explore both paths in the two chapters that follow, beginning with the older of the two.

The Gnostic Serpent

In December 1945, some Egyptian farmers digging near the town of Nag Hammadi, in Upper Egypt, stumbled upon a sealed earthenware jar containing thirteen leather-bound codices, written in Coptic and dating to the fourth century, but copied from much older Greek originals. That discovery, known today as the Nag Hammadi library, returned to the modern world dozens of gnostic texts believed lost forever, destroyed by the campaigns of orthodox repression of the early Christian centuries. Among these texts are some that tell the story of Eden in a way that radically overturns the meaning orthodox tradition had assigned to it.

The most explicit text on this point is the one scholars call the *Hypostasis of the Archons*, included in the critical edition curated by Bentley Layton and extensively discussed by the historian of religion Elaine Pagels in her influential study of the gnostic gospels. According to this text, the god who creates the material world and imposes the prohibition on the tree of knowledge is not the true supreme God, but an inferior and ignorant entity, called Yaldabaoth, who acts out of envy and a desire to keep humanity submissive and unaware. In this reversed reading, the serpent who advises Eve to eat the fruit is not an evil tempter, but a messenger bringing humans a knowledge the jealous god of the material world wished to deny them.

In another text from the same library, the *Apocryphon of John*, the

figure who takes the form of the serpent is explicitly identified with an emanation of the higher divine wisdom, come to awaken in human beings the memory of their spiritual origin, trapped in matter by the ignorant demiurge. In this theological framework, radically different from that of canonical Genesis, eating the fruit of the tree of knowledge is not a sin to be atoned for, but the first step of an awakening to be pursued, and the shame that follows is not the just consequence of guilt, but the sign of the oppression imposed by the creator of the material world, who punishes humans precisely for having drawn near the knowledge he himself wished to deny them.

Between the strictest orthodoxy and the radical gnostic reversal there is also, it should be said for completeness, a middle way, represented by another great Christian thinker of the early centuries: Origen of Alexandria. While remaining fully within the ecclesial communion of his time, unlike the gnostic authors who were expelled as heretics, Origen developed an allegorical reading of the Edenic story that, without ever denying the historical reality of the fall, strongly emphasized its symbolic meaning regarding the soul and its faculties, in a direction owing not a little to the exegetical method already employed by Philo centuries earlier. Origen himself, according to ancient historical sources such as the historian Eusebius of Caesarea, is said to have taken his own ambivalence toward sexuality to an extreme through a drastic act upon his own person, an episode that, whether or not authentic in its details, nonetheless testifies to how deeply early Christianity perceived a close and problematic link between the highest spiritual life and renunciation of the sexual sphere, a distant but recognizable echo of the same intuition running through this entire essay.

It is significant, for the theme of this essay, that in various texts of this tradition the knowledge awakened by the serpent is explicitly associated with the discovery of one's own bodily and sexual nature, presented not as a degeneration but as an integral part of self-awareness. Some gnostic texts, such as the Gospel of Philip, develop an elaborate theology of sexuality as the earthly image of a higher spiritual union, further overturning the ascetic reading orthodox tradition would impose on the same material. In this perspective, the nakedness discovered in Eden is not a cause for shame in any absolute sense, but becomes so only because of the oppressive order imposed by the demiurge, an order the gnostic texts themselves invite their readers to overcome through knowledge, the gnosis that gives this entire current of thought its name.

It must be said with the utmost clarity that this gnostic tradition in no way represents mainstream Christianity, ancient or modern. It was condemned as heresy by leading Church Fathers, from Irenaeus of Lyon to Tertullian, in the very early centuries when these texts circulated, and its vision of an ignorant demiurge set against a transcendent supreme God clashes head-on with classical monotheistic theology, both Jewish and Christian. We are not presenting gnosticism as a more authentic or more original reading of the biblical text than the orthodox one: the overwhelming majority of scholars of early Christian history, including Elaine Pagels herself in her more cautious conclusions, place the gnostic texts as theological developments of the second and third centuries, shaped in a philosophical context influenced by Middle Platonism, not as testimonies to a lost original meaning of the story of Genesis.

But the value of this tradition for our essay lies not in its supposed

historical authenticity, but in confirming that already in antiquity, only a few centuries after the composition of the New Testament texts, there existed religious communities reading the story of Eden in exactly the terms this essay is exploring: an event concerning the body, self-knowledge, and sexuality, read not as guilt but as threshold, not as fall but as possible awakening. Whether this is a correct interpretation of the original text or a later, ideologically motivated rereading, it remains a historical fact that this reading exists, is documented, and survived long enough to be found buried in an earthenware jar in the Egyptian desert nearly two thousand years after it was written.

With this second interpretive strand before us, the one that overturns the moral judgment on the episode while still keeping it within the symbolic and spiritual register, we can now address the last and most radical of the readings this essay sets out to examine: one that does not read the episode of Eden as a symbol of something else at all, but as the account, distorted by millennia, of a real biological intervention, carried out by entities with the technical capacity to alter the reproductive physiology of the human species.

CHAPTER 8

Enki, Enlil, and the Forbidden Fruit

In Mesopotamian tradition, two great deities dominate the stories of creation and the fate of humanity: Enki and Enlil. According to the Babylonian poem of Atrahasis, reconstructed by Assyriologists from various cuneiform tablets, whose standard critical edition was produced by Wilfred G. Lambert and Alan R. Millard, the two deities decided together to create humanity to free the lesser gods from the burden of labor, and later found themselves in disagreement when the human population grew to the point of disturbing divine rest. Enlil, the irritable ruler of the gods, repeatedly tried to reduce humanity through plague, drought, and finally the flood, while Enki, a more benevolent protector of his own creation, intervened every time to save it, going so far as to break the gods' oath in order to warn Atrahasis, his human protégé, of the coming catastrophe.

It is within this same pattern of conflict between two divine entities with opposing intentions toward humanity that the ancient-astronaut tradition, and in particular the reconstruction proposed by Zecharia Sitchin starting with his first book, *The 12th Planet*, also places the story of Eden. According to this reconstruction, humanity was not created by the Anunnaki as a fully autonomous species from the outset, but as a primitive workforce, genetically shaped from already-existing terrestrial hominids, with the specific purpose of performing the heaviest labor in place of the Anunnaki themselves, particularly in the mines. Such a workforce, Sitchin argues, would have been deliberately designed without the full capacity to reproduce

autonomously, so as to remain permanently dependent on its creators for its own renewal, exactly like any living being obtained through targeted genetic manipulation and lacking the capacity to generate fertile offspring.

In this reading, the garden of Eden would not be a generic mythical place, but a kind of experimental enclave or reserved residence, in which the Anunnaki kept the first specimens of this engineered humanity, Adam and Eve, under close control. The tree of the knowledge of good and evil would represent, in this light, not a literal fruit but an access, granted or denied, to a genetic technology capable of completing the reproductive process the creators had deliberately left incomplete. And it is here that the conflict between Enki and Enlil, documented in the poem of Atrahasis, would resurface: Enki, identified by this tradition with the figure of the serpent or at least with the entity acting through it, would have decided to secretly complete the genetic makeup of his own creation, allowing human beings to reproduce autonomously, against the explicit will of Enlil, who wanted to keep humanity in a state of total, controlled dependence.

It is worth recalling how the poem of Atrahasis describes the very creation of humanity: the greater gods, to free themselves from the heaviest labor, decide to shape the first humans by mixing clay with the blood and flesh of a lesser god specially sacrificed for the purpose, so that the intelligence and something of the divine essence of that sacrificed god would pass into the new creature, while still keeping it distinct from and subordinate to its creators. This same pattern, a humanity created in the image and substance of the gods but placed in a position of service and dependence, finds a striking

echo in the first chapter of Genesis, when God, again with a plural verb, says let us make man in our image, after our likeness. Here too, as with the plural in chapter three already discussed, the Hebrew text presupposes a group of divine listeners or interlocutors, not a single God speaking to himself, a detail the traditional reading explains differently but which the alternative reading we are examining interprets as a further trace of that same council of entities which, according to this reconstruction, generated and then oversaw the new species.

This reading offers, it must be acknowledged, an unusually coherent explanation for a detail of the biblical text the traditional theological reading struggles to explain with the same precision: the reaction of the Elohim, expressed in the plural, immediately after the transgression. The Hebrew text records the words behold, the man has become like one of us, knowing good and evil, a plural statement that presupposes a group of divine listeners, not a single God speaking to himself. In the traditional reading, this plural is explained as a plural of majesty, an honorific linguistic convention, or as a reference to the angels of the heavenly court. In the alternative reading we are examining, that plural instead becomes a literal reference to a council of Anunnaki, alarmed that one of their own, Enki, had just allowed the experimental workforce to acquire a capacity that would make it autonomous, able to reproduce on its own, no longer wholly dependent on its creators.

This reading also allows a coherent rereading of the immediate death threat that, as we noted in the first chapter of this essay, is not fulfilled: in the day you eat of it, you shall surely die, God had said to Adam concerning the forbidden fruit, and yet Adam does not die that

day. If we read the prohibition not as a threat of immediate physical death, but as a warning that unauthorized access to that genetic technology would compromise the carefully calibrated biological stability of the engineered organism, perhaps drastically shortening its lifespan relative to that of its creators, then the threat aligns perfectly with what the biblical text itself documents in the following chapters: the progressive collapse of human longevity across the generations following the expulsion from Eden, from the roughly nine hundred years of the first patriarchs down to the hundred-and-twenty-year limit God declares immediately before the flood. In this overall reading, Eden and the flood become two chapters of the same story: the partial, unauthorized granting of full reproductive capacity in Eden, followed, generations later, by the progressive reduction of the lifespan that capacity entailed, down to the limit finally fixed at the time of the flood.

This reading fits, moreover, into a thematic continuity running through the whole first part of Genesis. In chapter six, only a few generations after the expulsion from Eden, the text again stages a contact between a celestial population and the human population that produces direct consequences for the latter's biology: the sons of God uniting with the daughters of men and fathering the Nephilim, a hybrid offspring of immense strength the text places right before the flood narrative. If the alternative reading examined in this chapter is correct, the episode of Eden and the episode of the Nephilim would not be two disconnected events, but two moments of the same, broader pattern: a first genetic contact, that between Enki and the primordial couple, unlocking humanity's autonomous reproductive capacity, and a second contact, that of the sons of God with the

daughters of men, reintroducing celestial genetic material into a human population now reproductively autonomous, generating the gigantic hybrids the flood would later have to erase. In this overall reading, the primordial history of Genesis becomes the account, fragmented and transmitted through apparently distinct episodes, of a repeated series of genetic interventions on the human species by the same celestial entities, each followed by different consequences and reactions from the rest of the divine council.

As always in this kind of inquiry, the line between what is documented and what is interpretation must be drawn honestly. That the Hebrew text uses plural forms both in the account of creation, let us make man in our image, and in the sentence pronounced after the transgression, the man has become like one of us, is an established grammatical fact, visible to anyone reading the original text. The traditional reading explains these plurals as plurals of majesty or as references to the angelic court; the alternative reading reads them as literal traces of a plurality of real actors with conflicting agendas. These are two different interpretive keys applied to the same textual data, and the text, by itself, imposes neither one nor the other: both start from the same words and draw opposite conclusions, according to the overall framework within which each reader chooses to place them. The same holds for the tree of knowledge read as reproductive technology, for Adam and Eve read as engineered organisms, and for the identification of the serpent with Enki: these are interpretations, not demonstrated facts, but they are interpretations built on real textual anomalies, the divine plural, the unfulfilled death threat, the punishment centered on reproduction, that any reading, traditional or alternative, must in some way account for.

That said, the reason this reading continues to attract a very wide audience, well beyond the bounds of academic biblical criticism, is not hard to understand: it offers a single, coherent explanation for a series of details the text presents separately, without explicitly linking them, the divine plural, the non-immediate death threat, the punishment centered on reproduction, the progressive decline in longevity narrated in the following chapters of Genesis. Whether this coherence is the sign of a historical truth hidden behind the veil of myth, or simply the product of the human capacity to build comprehensive narratives out of scattered elements, remains, as always in this kind of inquiry, a question the available facts do not allow us to close definitively.

It is worth closing this chapter by observing that the three readings examined in this essay, the philological and narrative reading of the opening chapters, the patristic and gnostic reading of the early Christian centuries, and the ancient-astronaut reading of the contemporary era, all share, though starting from radically different premises, the same underlying dissatisfaction with the more superficial reading of the story as a simple act of disobedience punished. Each, in its own way, seeks something more specific behind the veil of the text: a precise linguistic origin, an inverted theology of liberation, a literal biological event. That none of these three readings can alone claim the last word on the meaning of the story takes nothing away from the value of the exercise: it only reminds us that humanity's oldest and most-read texts remain, millennia later, still capable of generating genuine questions, not just reassuring answers.

CONCLUSION

What Opened

We began with two verses placed side by side: naked and without shame, then eyes opened and ashamed of nakedness. We chose not to quickly leap over this hinge to reach the theological drama of disobedience, as the more customary reading does, but to stop exactly there, and ask why the text, at the crucial moment of the story, chooses to speak of bodies and not of abstract guilt.

We found, in the Hebrew verb *yada*, a documented and undeniable linguistic ambiguity, linking the name of the forbidden tree to the very verb that, a few lines later, describes the union between Adam and Eve. We observed how the scene of the discovery of nakedness, God's question about who revealed that nakedness, and the punishment of the woman centered entirely on pregnancy and marital desire, together build an insistently bodily picture that no amount of exegetical caution can fully dissolve into pure metaphor. We noted an often-ignored structural fact, the absence of any birth within the garden, and the placement of the first sexual union and the first birth immediately after the expulsion. We found, in the Epic of Gilgamesh, an independent and well-documented Mesopotamian parallel, in which a specific sexual initiation marks the irreversible passage from an innocent animal state to a conscious human condition. We traced, in the garments of skin of Adam and Eve and in the Augustinian doctrine of concupiscence, a historical thread showing how deeply even the most orthodox theology tied the fall to the sexed body. We

read, in the gnostic texts of Nag Hammadi, a radical reversal of the same material, in which the awakening of bodily awareness becomes liberation rather than guilt. And finally we considered the most radical hypothesis, the one linking the story of Eden to the conflict between Enki and Enlil narrated in the poem of Atrahasis, reading the whole episode as the distorted memory of a real genetic intervention.

As always in this kind of inquiry, none of these elements, taken alone, proves anything conclusively. The verb *yada* remains ambiguous, not univocal. The parallel with Enkidu remains a structural parallel, not proof of direct dependence. The gnostic reading remains a second-century theological reinterpretation, not a testimony to a lost original meaning. The Anunnaki hypothesis remains an interpretation, not a demonstrated fact. But the convergence of so many different traditions, often hostile to one another, often separated by centuries or millennia and by no direct contact, around the same underlying intuition, that the story of Eden is, at its core, about the body and its sexuality, remains a fact that deserves to be taken seriously, regardless of which specific interpretation one chooses to favor.

It is worth noting, in closing, how this convergence crosses not only different eras but also mutually incompatible theological positions. Augustine and the gnostics his own Church would condemn as heretics could not be further apart in their moral evaluation of sexuality, the one reading it as the scar of guilt, the others as the sign of a possible liberating awakening. And yet both, starting from opposite premises, locate at the very same point of the story, the discovery of nakedness and desire, the center of gravity of the entire Edenic episode. This agreement between otherwise irreconcilable positions, reached without either tradition intending in the least to

confirm the other, is perhaps the strongest clue this essay can offer: not proof of a single correct interpretation, but proof that the text itself, in a way that escapes any purely moralistic reading of disobedience, continues to speak, to anyone who reads it with sufficient attention, of the discovery of the body as a founding event of the human condition.

Perhaps the story of Eden is only a splendid literary reflection on the birth of adult moral consciousness, and nakedness only the most immediate and effective symbol an ancient storyteller could choose to represent it. That is the more cautious reading, and the one that, with good reason, will continue to be the most widespread. But if even part of what this essay has gathered preserved the memory of something more specific, then the question we carry with us as we close these pages no longer concerns only Adam and Eve. It concerns why, among all the possible sins a founding text could have chosen to tell the beginning of the human condition, that choice fell, with such insistence and for so many millennia, precisely on the moment two beings looked at each other, saw each other for the first time, and felt ashamed.

METHODOLOGICAL NOTE

This essay moves between two distinct planes that it is essential to keep separate. The first plane is that of documented facts: the use of the Hebrew verb *yada* for both intellectual knowledge and the sexual act, the narrative structure of the second and third chapters of Genesis, the absence of any narrated births within Eden, the content of the Enkidu and Shamhat episode in the Epic of Gilgamesh, the Augustinian doctrine of concupiscence, the content of the gnostic texts of the Nag Hammadi library. These are verifiable textual and historical data, on which solid philological consensus exists, even when their ultimate interpretation remains a matter of debate.

The second plane is that of hypothesis. Reading the tree of knowledge as reproductive technology, identifying the serpent with Enki, the idea that Adam and Eve were the product of genetic engineering carried out by the Anunnaki, and more generally any reading that presents the story of Eden as the distorted account of a real biological event rather than as a literary and theological construction, belong to this second plane, and have been declared as such at every point in the text where they appear. They are not offered as demonstrated truths, but as possible interpretive keys, consistent with the documented textual anomalies but not proven by them.

The sources, as in previous essays, are divided into two sections: the academic ones, which form the verifiable documentary basis of the work, and those of the alternative tradition, which represent the interpretive current within which the more speculative part of the

essay is situated.

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